

Degree of DESPAIR

Once a ticket to corporate success, an MBA now is not even enough to get students a job

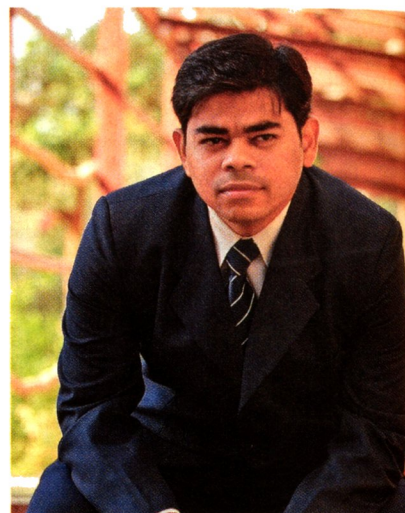
By Nandini Vaish

Amit Varshney, 29, thought he had it good when he enrolled at the K.J. Somaiya Institute of Management Studies & Research, Mumbai, two years ago. With four years of work experience and an MBA from one of India's top 25 B-Schools, he was confident of a job in the manufacturing sector with a salary of at least Rs 8-10 lakh a year. He had also planned on getting married after that.

Unfortunately, things didn't quite turn out that way. K.J. Somaiya was one of the many institutes to feel the brunt of the recession, managing only 153 placements in a batch of 290 so far. Varshney is left without a job and no savings. Those were used to pay for his MBA and no recruiter is willing to offer him even what he was earning before (Rs 4.2 lakh). At best he was being offered the profile of a management trainee. "MBAs and engineers are going at the price of potatoes," he says somewhat cynically. The marriage plans too, have been postponed. But he counts himself among the more

fortunate ones, not having a family to support. His batchmate Manoj too hasn't been placed, despite eight years of work experience, and has a family to take care of.

Gone are the days when students had the luxury of choosing from at least three to five offers each. Remember the IIM Ahmedabad students who turned down crore-ruppee offers in 2006? For the Class of 2009, it's none of that. Thanks to the hiring freeze at most companies, even candidates with the right skills and experience are finding it difficult. Even after months of 'rolling placements', many institutes, including the prestigious Indian School of Business (ISB), Hyderabad, have managed to place only 80 per cent of their 437-strong batch. While the top 15 schools have managed



Amit Varshney, 29

K.J. SOMAIYA INSTITUTE OF MANAGEMENT STUDIES & RESEARCH, MUMBAI

Could not get a campus placement despite four years of work experience; his savings have been used to pay for his MBA. From a salary of Rs 4.2 lakh, he is left without a job.

"Sometimes having work experience is more of a bane than a boon."

Nikhil Bansal, 23

BIRLA INSTITUTE OF MANAGEMENT TECHNOLOGY, NOIDA

With specialisation in retail management, he was hoping to work for a sales and marketing job with a Rs 5-5.5 lakh compensation. Has a loan of Rs 5.72 lakh to repay.

"I'd rather wait than settle for a lower profile as I'll never be able to grow in my career."

REUBEN SINGH

